



PROVIDENCE ENGLISH PRIVATE SCHOOL

School Canteen & Healthy Nutrition Policy

2026 – 2027

To encourage healthy eating habits among students.

Document Title	School Canteen & Healthy Nutrition Policy
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Responsible For Implementation	School Administration & Canteen Team
Linked Policies	Whole-School Wellbeing Policy; Health & Safety Policy; Inclusion Policy; Behaviour & Discipline Policy; Parent-School Communication Policy
Regulatory Framework	Sharjah Municipality food safety and canteen licensing requirements; Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA); UAE Ministry of Education (MOE) school nutrition guidance

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1. Purpose & Objectives

Providence English Private School (PEPS) is committed to encouraging healthy eating habits among students. This policy sets out the standards for food and drink provided through the school canteen, and the wider approach to nutrition, food safety, and healthy habits that applies across the school day.

The objectives of this policy are to:

- Ensure the food and drink available through the school canteen supports students' health, growth, and concentration;
- Provide a variety of appealing, balanced options that reflect good nutrition;
- Maintain the highest standards of food safety and hygiene in the preparation and service of food;
- Support students with allergies or specific dietary requirements to eat safely at school;
- Build students' knowledge and lifelong habits around healthy eating through education, not just restriction.

2. Scope

This policy applies to all students at PEPS and covers food and drink provided by the school canteen, food brought from home, and food served at school-organised events and celebrations. Responsibility for implementing this policy rests with School Administration and the Canteen Team, working together with teachers and parents.

3. Legal & Regulatory Framework

This policy is written in accordance with Sharjah Municipality's food safety and canteen licensing requirements, and reflects the school nutrition guidance issued by the Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA) and the UAE Ministry of Education (MOE). The school canteen operates under a valid food trade licence and is subject to periodic inspection in line with these requirements.

4. Guiding Principles

- Health-supportive by default: the everyday canteen menu is built around balanced, nutritious options, with less healthy items available only occasionally or in limited form.
- Variety and choice: students are offered a genuine variety of appealing healthy options, not a single restrictive menu.
- Safety first: food safety and allergy management take priority over all other considerations in canteen operations.
- Education alongside provision: healthy habits are taught, modelled, and encouraged, not simply mandated.
- Partnership with families: the school and parents share responsibility for a student's overall diet, recognising that the canteen is one part of a student's day.

5. Canteen Menu Standards

The school canteen menu is planned to offer a balanced variety of food groups across the week, including fresh fruit and vegetables, whole grains, lean proteins, and dairy or dairy alternatives. Menus are reviewed periodically by School Administration and the Canteen Team to maintain nutritional balance, variety, and appeal to students across all age groups, and to reflect feedback received (see Section 16).

6. Restricted & Discouraged Items

The following are not sold through the school canteen:

- Energy drinks and any beverages containing added stimulants;
- Carbonated soft drinks;
- Confectionery and snacks that are the primary item on offer (rather than a limited, occasional addition to a balanced meal).

Deep-fried foods, foods high in added sugar, and processed snacks are offered only occasionally and in limited portions, rather than as everyday staples, in line with the school's commitment to a health-supportive everyday menu. Illustrative examples are provided in Appendix A.

7. Food Safety & Hygiene

The Canteen Team maintains the highest standards of food safety and hygiene at all times, including:

- Holding and maintaining a valid food trade licence with Sharjah Municipality;
- Ensuring all canteen staff hold valid, up-to-date food safety/hygiene certification;
- Following safe food storage, preparation, and temperature control practices at all times;
- Maintaining clean and hygienic food preparation and service areas, subject to regular inspection;
- Cooperating fully with any inspection by Sharjah Municipality or other relevant authority.

8. Allergies & Dietary Requirements

Parents are asked to inform the school office and the Canteen Team of any food allergy, intolerance, or specific dietary requirement (e.g. religious or cultural dietary needs) at the point of admission and whenever this changes. This information is recorded and shared confidentially with relevant staff on a need-to-know basis, in line with the school's Data Protection & Privacy Policy.

The Canteen Team clearly labels common allergens in food sold through the canteen wherever practicable, and takes reasonable steps to prevent cross-contamination for known student allergies. Parents of a student with a significant or life-threatening allergy are encouraged to discuss individual arrangements directly with the school office and, where relevant, the Student Counsellor.

9. Packed Lunches & Snacks from Home

Where students bring food from home, parents are encouraged to pack balanced, healthy options consistent with the spirit of this policy. To protect students with severe allergies, students are asked not to share food brought from home with classmates, and classrooms may operate specific restrictions (for example, a nut-

aware classroom) where a student's medical needs require it, communicated to affected families via the appropriate channel.

10. Water & Hydration

Students are encouraged to drink water regularly throughout the school day, particularly given the local climate. Water is freely accessible to students, and students are encouraged to bring a reusable water bottle to school each day.

11. Celebrations, Treats & Special Occasions

PEPS recognises that celebrations, such as birthdays and cultural or religious occasions, are a meaningful part of school life, and occasional treats are permitted on these occasions. Class teachers coordinate any food brought in for a celebration with parents in advance, to check for allergies and dietary requirements among the class, in line with Section 8.

12. Nutrition Education

Healthy eating is reinforced through the curriculum (for example, in science, PE, and pastoral/PSHE lessons), assemblies, and awareness activities, helping students understand the reasons behind healthy choices rather than simply being told what they can and cannot buy.

13. Canteen Operations & Mealtime Supervision

The Canteen Team manages queuing, service, and seating arrangements to ensure mealtimes run smoothly and safely, and teaching staff and Section Supervisors provide appropriate supervision during break and lunch periods, including support for younger students who may need help managing food, allergies, or portions.

14. Pricing & Accessibility

Canteen pricing is set to be reasonable and transparent, with prices displayed clearly at the point of sale. Families experiencing financial difficulty are encouraged to speak confidentially with the school's Social Worker or the school office regarding support options.

15. Roles & Responsibilities

School Administration

Holds overall responsibility for setting and monitoring canteen standards, approving the menu framework, and ensuring the canteen operator's licensing and food safety compliance.

Canteen Team

Prepares and serves food in line with this policy and all food safety requirements, manages allergen labelling and cross-contamination precautions, and maintains a clean, well-run service.

Teachers & Section Supervisors

Reinforce healthy eating messages, supervise mealtimes appropriately, and communicate any class-specific dietary considerations (e.g. for a celebration) to parents.

Parents

Support healthy eating at home and in packed lunches, inform the school of any allergy or dietary requirement, and cooperate with any classroom-specific food safety arrangements.

16. Monitoring, Feedback & Menu Review

School Administration and the Canteen Team review the canteen menu periodically, taking into account nutritional balance, food safety inspection outcomes, and feedback gathered from students, parents, and staff. Feedback can be shared through the school office or via the channels set out in the Parent-School Communication Policy.

17. Non-Compliance

Where a student repeatedly brings restricted items from home in a way that creates a safety concern for others (for example, an allergen in a nut-aware classroom), the matter is addressed sensitively by the class teacher or Section Supervisor with the family concerned. Where the Canteen Team or canteen operator fails to meet the standards set out in this policy, School Administration addresses this directly with the operator, up to and including review of the catering contract.

18. Sustainability & Waste

The Canteen Team is encouraged to minimise food waste and single-use packaging where practicable, and students are encouraged to take only what they intend to eat and to dispose of waste responsibly.

19. Policy Review

This policy is monitored by School Administration and the Canteen Team, and reviewed periodically to ensure it remains aligned with SPEA, MOE, and Sharjah Municipality requirements, and reflects best practice in school nutrition.

Appendix A: Encouraged vs Restricted Items

This table describes the school's canteen menu standards at an institutional level. It is not intended as individual dietary or nutrition advice for any student.

Category	Encouraged (Everyday)	Occasional / Limited	Not Sold in Canteen
Drinks	Water, milk, unsweetened natural juice	Flavoured milk	Energy drinks; carbonated soft drinks
Snacks	Fresh fruit, vegetable sticks, nuts/seeds (where classroom allergy status allows)	Baked snacks, low-sugar granola bars	Sweets and confectionery as a primary canteen item
Mains	Grilled proteins, whole grains, salads, balanced hot meals	Occasional fried items in limited portions	—
Bakery	Whole-grain bread and wraps	Pastries, cakes (occasional)	—

Appendix B: Allergy & Food Safety Quick Reference

For Parents

- Inform the school office and Canteen Team of any allergy or dietary requirement at admission and whenever it changes.
- Check with your child's teacher before sending in food for a class celebration.
- Label packed lunches and snacks with your child's name, particularly in the Foundation Stage and Primary section.

For the Canteen Team

- Maintain valid food safety certification and food trade licensing at all times.
- Label common allergens on canteen food wherever practicable.
- Take reasonable precautions to avoid cross-contamination for known student allergies.
- Report any food safety concern to School Administration immediately.

This appendix should be read alongside the Whole-School Wellbeing Policy and Health & Safety Policy.